> "DURING THE DAY, THEY GENERALLY DISAPPEAR, SLEEPING AND HIDING BENEATH THICK JUNGLE CANOPIES, TAKING REFUGE IN HILLSIDE CAVES."
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> ARTICLE IN US *TIME* MAGAZINE, 21 JULY 1967



Vietnam War
The Vietnam War was a conflict between communist North Vietnam (backed by China and Russia) and the US-backed South Vietnamese government. It also spilled over into Laos and Cambodia.

THE VIETNAM WAR 1965–1975

South Vietnam
North Vietnam

Communist supply lines
Ho Chi Minh trail
Sihanouk trail

Vietcong and NVA offensives
Tet offensive 1968
Viet Cong Eastertide offensive 1972
Final offensive 1974–75

Major battles with US involvement
1965–66
1967–69

that they barbecued in a flame. Guerrillas were paid 60 piasters (about $2) a month, which they used to order luxuries such as sugar, soap, and tobacco that supply officers would purchase in Cambodian markets. Amusements were rare. The guerrillas trained endlessly or sat through classes in which they were taught revolutionary slogans or updated on world news. An occasional visiting entertainment unit would be welcome despite its generally repetitious programmes of uplifting patriotic films and songs. To counter homesickness, guerrillas were occasionally given leave, although travelling through a war zone to visit their families was hazardous.

Attack by a US search-and-destroy sweep or by aerial bombardment instantly replaced any boredom with fear. The men might have to flee at a moment's notice and then move through the forest for days on end, hiding desperately from the enemy by day and sleeping in a hammock slung between two trees at night. By general agreement, most terrifying of all was a B-52 bomber strike, in which a whole area of forest would erupt with a roar that tore eardrums and shook nerves to the core. Sheltering in tunnels, many of which contained kitchens, sleeping rooms, and makeshift hospitals, offered some protection, but there was always the fear that they might collapse and bury their occupants alive. Some guerrillas had to be hospitalized with shell shock after persistent bombing.

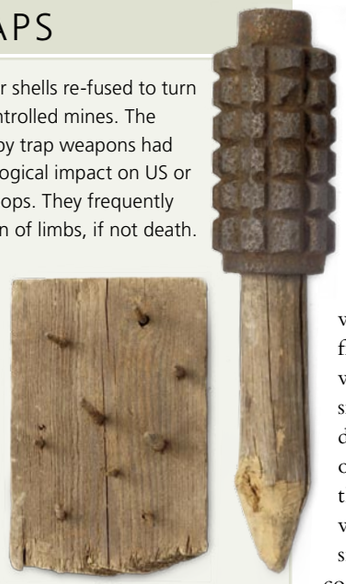
TET AND AFTER

In January–February 1968, the Viet Cong took advantage of the new year, or Tet, celebrations, when many South Vietnamese soldiers would be on leave, and occupied cities and towns across South Vietnam. Leading to the brief occupation of Saigon, the capital, the Tet Offensive, as it was known, dealt a fatal blow to America's will to continue the war, but at the cost of massive guerrilla casualties. There were many thousands of defections from the Viet Cong in the following year, as men found the tension and hardship of years of guerrilla life cumulatively unbearable. But desertions were never as numerous as from the government forces. A member of the Viet Cong political leadership, Truong Nhu Trang, wrote: "Although the guerrillas were short of food and often sick, they maintained the kind of esprit and comradeship that animates people who are fighting for a common purpose in which they believe with all their hearts. They got on, under horrendous conditions, through mutual support and a rough but genuine love for each other."

In the end, however, the defeat of the South Vietnamese government in 1975 was achieved by the North Vietnamese Army fighting a conventional war with conventional weapons, such as tanks and artillery. Militarily sidelined, many Viet Cong guerrillas were also disillusioned with the outcome of the war. Few of the rank and file had been communists and the harsh austerity of the reunified Vietnam was not what they had wanted, which was simply an end to foreign interference in their country and a better life for their families.

VIET CONG BOOBY TRAPS

Booby trap devices played a large part in the small-scale guerrilla war waged around the villages in Vietnam. One of the most effective – and most primitive – of these was the punji stick. Villagers sharpened pieces of bamboo, coated their tips with faeces or some other infectious substance, and planted them upright in the ground under a covering of leaves or grass. If a soldier stepped on it, the stick would pierce the sole of his boot. Whole clearings were sometimes planted with punji sticks in an attempt to stop them being used as helicopter landing zones. When the Americans thickened their boot soles to resist punji sticks, the guerrillas invented a device made of two spiked panels that, when trodden on, penetrated the leg above the boot. Other booby trap devices included grenades attached to a tripwire made of fishing line and purloined US howitzer shells re-fused to turn them into remote-controlled mines. The guerrillas' use of booby trap weapons had a devastating psychological impact on US or South Vietnamese troops. They frequently resulted in amputation of limbs, if not death. Sometimes guerrilla snipers would cover the site of a booby trap, ready to add to the mayhem.



Spiked booby traps
Common Viet Cong booby traps were the spike plate and the grenade (here without its trip wire).